

Albania



Lying at the southeastern end of the Adriatic Sea, Albania was the last east European country to liberalize its economy. The regional strife of the 1990s has left a difficult legacy.



GEOGRAPHY

Narrow coastal plain. Interior is mostly hills and mountains. Forest and scrub cover over 40% of the land.



CLIMATE

Mediterranean coastal climate, with warm summers and cool winters. Mountains receive heavy rains or snows in winter.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The pace of economic reform remains a major issue. EU membership, applied for in 2009, is a distant prospect. Mosques and churches have reopened in what was once the world's only officially atheist state. The Greek minority in the south suffers much discrimination.



INSIGHT: *The Albanians' name for their country, Shqipërisë, means "Land of the Eagles"*



THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas reserves have potential to offset rudimentary infrastructure and lack of foreign investment. Organized crime problem.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Albania

DATE OF FORMATION: 1912

CAPITAL: Tirana

POPULATION: 3.16 million

TOTAL AREA: 11,100 sq. miles
(28,748 sq. km)

DENSITY: 298 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Albanian*, Greek

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 70%,
Orthodox Christian 20%,
Roman Catholic 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Albanian 93%, Greek 5%,
other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Lek = 100 qindarka (qintars)